though only an infant institution, it gives every promise of soon becoming the backbone of a great and broad-based commercial concern which will, in course of time, confer untold blessings on the country.'[107]

As could be expected, following the purchase of two ships, the company received a fillip with many shares being subscribed and many new share applications being received daily.[108]

The mood was so upbeat that SSNCo declared that it was considering the purchase of four more steamers at a total cost of Rs 6,00,000.[109]

Captain and Crew

Running a ship is a specialized profession. So, who ran the Swadeshi steamers?

Despite the company's ideological commitment to employ Indians as crew this was not feasible. Mercantile marine was an international business run on professional lines. With huge capital investment and valuable cargo and passenger lives at stake, only certified sailors could man the ships. Race was a defining feature of the crew. Europeans dominated seafaring. While Indian seamen cleaned, scoured, kept watch, dropped anchor on the decks and stoked the fires in the engine rooms below, captains, engineers and boiler-makers—all well-paid—were European without exception. As the crew had to be certified by international agencies, the expenses and rigours of the certification process for non-Whites can scarcely be imagined. Consequently, there were few avenues for any certified Indian sailor 'barring the odd Parsi driver, junior engineer or deck officer'[110]—precisely why SSNCo, in its founding documents, held out the promise of establishing schools to train Indians and other Asians in navigation. Even in the 1920s, at the time of the Indian Mercantile Marine Committee, while Indian entrepreneurs demanded the training of Indians in navigation, European shipping interests, not to mention white seafarers themselves, were hostile to the idea.

In keeping with its remit of encouraging and employing Asians, SSNCo, in theory at least, had the option of hiring Japanese sailors. But this was far